

Trapped in the Closet

AS LONG AS YOU DON'T MARRY, YOU DON'T GROW UP. NEITHER YOU NOR YOUR FAMILY IS FORCED TO ACKNOWLEDGE THAT YOU MAY BE GAY.

My mother's heart aches every time she knits a fluffy woollen sweater for another new grand niece or nephew. "My fingers are getting arthritic. Who knows if I'll be able to knit another one?" she complains, sitting in the buttery sunshine of a Kolkata winter, the ball of wool rolling on the bedspread. The question she doesn't ask hangs in the air: "When will I get to knit something for your children?"

My grandmother carefully preserved my mother's clothes so my sister and I could wear them as children. My nephew still wears my old sweaters and long out-of-fashion corduroys. But in my coming out, my mother fears, that carefully nurtured thread of continuity is somewhere snapping.

Coming out in India is really about marriage. In fact, the standard coming-out line is, "Ma, Baba, I don't think I am going to get married at all." But as long as you don't marry, you also don't grow up. "I can squeeze your cheeks just like when you were a boy," a neighbour told me on a recent visit to India. In their eyes I am not gay. I am simply "unmarried", one of the "lost boys" trapped in Peter Pan's Neverland.

But S. was the real lost boy. He went to my school, now runs his own company and was active in the alumni

society. I remember being so excited when I went to his office to meet him, sure we would have so much to talk about. But S. was already married with a child. All I remember is the darting terror in his eyes as if my mere presence would out him. We never met again.

for Lesbians and Gays from India, complete with a "gaylerry" of posted ads.

My friend told me about how he was having sex with a man he had met and in the middle his wife called and he kept talking to her. My friend got up and left. He could leave,

Pride in kurtas, while the sound system on the caparisoned truck blares, "Pyar kiya to darna kiya."

In 1993, my friend Aditya went to India with his boyfriend Michael and complained to his mother that no one would ever come to his wedding. She promptly organised a ceremony. The family swamiji presided over it. "Openly gay and married in my parents' drawing room at the age of 30," marvelled Aditya. "Right on schedule as a good Indian boy should be." I recently watched his wedding video again at his home in Berkeley. In 2007, with all the talk of same-sex marriage, it still felt like a fairy tale, a lump-in-the-throat act of domestic revolution.

But the real revolution, says a friend, will come not when he can kiss his boyfriend on Park Street in



15% MARRIED MEN ADMIT TO GAY FANTASIES, DOWN FROM 21% IN THE 2004 SURVEY

But I hear his story in the voices of gays and lesbians who feel they've run out of all excuses to put off marriage—graduate school, Ph.D., job-hunt. I see it in desperate ads—25-year-old professional Indian gay, 5'9", good job, looking for pretty, feminine Indian lesbian facing similar family pressure. There was even a website devoted to Assisting Matrimonial Arrangements

but the man was stuck. That's why what impressed me most about the story of Manvendra Singh Gohil, the prince of Rajpipla, was not that he came out and risked being disowned by his family, but that he publicly apologised to his ex-wife in the courtroom. That's a far braver act than marching down the main street of San Francisco during Gay

Kolkata, not even when his parents will accept his sexuality. That already happens. The revolution will happen, he says, when his parents will find him a husband from a good family. It's time for a gay arranged marriage. And he's ready.

The writer was editor of Trikon Magazine which covers South Asian lesbian-gay-bisexual-transgender issues